

pad with an LCD display, and the MX-1000 mouse. It uses Bluetooth for wireless communication between these devices. The keyboard features the standard layout minus the number pad. The number pad is a separate unit so that it can be taken along with a laptop, since laptops don't have number pads. The same number pad unit doubles up as a Calculator, media centre remote via the MediaLife application, and shows the time and date in the normal mode. Logitech also has a non-laser version of the



There's a host of multimedia keys on the MX-3000



The scroll pad and zoom buttons on the Logitech MX-3000 keyboard/mouse combo

same product, called the diNovo Media Desktop.

Apart from these esoteric combos, the Logitech Cordless Desktop MX-3000 laser kit comprises the latest feature-rich keyboard and the MX-600 laser mouse. The keyboard has 32 extra keys that enable one-touch controlling of multimedia functions such as launching the default media player, eject, play/pause, stop, volume control, mute, shuffle, etc.

Apart from these standard features, it also has buttons for recording and burning. On the Internet front, it has buttons for messenger status and Web cam. Furthermore, it also incorporates a scroll wheel with horizontal as well as vertical scrolling—a boon if you frequent Web pages that require scrolling,

or work with large Excel Worksheets. If image editing is your thing, the Zoom and one-touch 100 per cent zoom buttons will come in handy.

The BenQ X-Touch 850 sports a radical design, with the keys laid out on a convex base, helping the hands to easily rest on the keys without creating any stress on the wrists. The mouse, however, isn't the best of the lot, and doesn't go well with the futuristic-looking keyboard.

The combo has been awarded the iF (International Forum Design) design award. Apart from the standard multimedia and Internet keys, the X-touch doesn't come with too many other features. The keyboard doesn't have indication for Caps, Num or Scroll locks—instead, a small on-screen display menu pops up in the system tray, which is rather useless, and irritating as well.

The iBall i-UFO completely stands out in the bunch and will definitely attract mass attention. It features a UFO-shaped wireless receiver with a blue light—very cool. Apart from the standard hotkeys such as those for multimedia and the Internet, the i-UFO comes with keys for launching MS Word and Excel. Bundled with the combo is a strange-looking mouse. The wide scroll wheel provides good comfort though.

The Genius LuxeMate Pro has a low-profile design giving it a sleek look, and a notebook-type, cramped keyboard. However, Genius has taken care not to mess up in terms of quality. The palm rest features a soft rubbery feel that makes it comfortable to use for long hours. Unlike other keyboards that either use alkaline batteries or Lithium-ion rechargeable cells, the LuxeMate pro keyboard comes with recharge-

able NiMH cells. Genius has gone a step forward, incorporating a battery charger in the wireless USB receiver, and the batteries can be charged via the USB ports.

No other keyboard is cramped with features as much as the Logitech MX-3000 laser set is, and there's no wonder it comes out tops as far as just features are concerned. The diNovo Media Desktop Laser set takes second place.

On the software front, Logitech is miles ahead of the other vendors in terms of the quality of software bundled with their products. The SetPoint application is intuitive, simple to configure, and has the best graphical user interface with proper comments and help. Genius, iBall and BenQ do bundle some software, but they will require a thorough overhaul to match up to the simplicity offered by Logitech's SetPoint application.

## Ergonomics

On the ergonomics front, the Logitech S510 Media Remote fares well. The keyboard has good tactile feel, but due to the short key travel (the depth to which a key can be pressed), getting used to it will take some time.

The remote is a piece of art and fits in your palm perfectly; all the keys are within easy reach. The only gripe we had with the remote was that the clickable scroll wheel was a little stiff. Coming to the bundled mouse, it is simply fantastic, and will fit perfectly in your palm. The weight bias is near-perfect, and doesn't feel heavy—despite the fact that it uses two AA batteries.

The Logitech diNovo Media desktop laser combo, despite its ambitious design, falls short of delivering the goods. Though the concept is unique, the implementation leaves a lot to be desired. The keyboard is similar in design to the ones seen on any laptop. The short key travel and close spacing between keys often makes typing cumbersome. Also, the left [Shift] is reduced in size, which often results in one's hitting the wrong key. The separate number pad has no issues, but its real-life value is questionable. The MX-1000 laser mouse has no such issues; in fact this



Genius TwinTouch SE Wireless Optical Desktop kit